

about the cloud, for example, we compete with Amazon. It's a proprietary platform. Similarly, we would compete with other open source cloud platforms. We see this competing as distinct from partnering with the open source ecosystem. The open source ecosystem is separate from the open source vendors. Red Hat is our competitor, and we compete with it.

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I think what people in India need to see is that Microsoft is not competing with the open source ecosystem or the ideology. I think this has been proven enough by the fact that more than 80 per cent of all open source projects that exist in the world run well on Windows as well. If we were not serious about really partnering with the open source ecosystem, we would have never built something that makes open source work on our system. For developers who really question if Microsoft is serious about this, my answer would be 'absolutely'. So, I would urge those developers to go to www.microsoft.com/openness to get a feel of what we are actually up to. There are open source enthusiasts who are as actively participating in projects as Microsoft is. That's what people in India need to see and that's my job. Given that India has the second largest developer base in the world, there need to be a whole lot of positive messages going out from our side. And we really want people to converse with us as much as possible.

Microsoft is investing in open source technologies like NODE.JS to make them mainstream on our platform. With the new IaaS offerings on Windows Azure, we now support various flavours of Linux on our popular cloud platform. So, it's up to Microsoft and the leaders of the open source community to start seeing this as an opportunity. If you develop an app that is not compatible with Windows, then you are simply cutting yourself out from almost 90 per cent of an opportunity. We don't want developers to do that. If people choose to be Java or PHP developers, we are not stopping them. We are, in fact, here to provide an extended opportunity to such developers to take their solutions to market. That's why it is important that the open source community and Microsoft work closely. Competition will remain, just like Red Hat competes with Canonical and SUSE. We are just a vendor when it comes to competing. So the 'competitive space' is very different. What unfortunately tends to happen is that people bring that competitive situation into the ideological conversations. For Microsoft, a developer is a developer. For the developer,

there are just two things that are important—to really drive the technology forward with passion and enthusiasm, and two, to be financially successful, and known for their good work. I don't see a reason why developers should be bound to a platform—be it open source or proprietary. They should have access to everything.

As interest in interoperability and open source evolved to the cloud and devices, we brought in Microsoft Open Technologies Inc as a wholly owned subsidiary. We believe it is the best way to serve developers, customers and partners better. Microsoft is committed to openness. Microsoft is becoming more open in the way that we work with and collaborate with others in the industry, in how we listen to customers, and in our approach to the cloud. While this subsidiary has been formed in the US, the existing openness initiatives and those going forward through this subsidiary will definitely benefit customers, developers and the open source ecosystem globally, including those in India.

Q So, if I were to read between the lines, is Microsoft giving open source developers a chance to commercialise their work?

It's not just about commercialisation. It is about innovation and ensuring that they are successful, both commercially and in terms of popularity. Why would a developer or a company invest a huge amount of time and resources on something that would not give them a great growth opportunity. That's what the fundamentals of any business are. Our view on the whole thing is that the developers should choose. If they think proprietary technology can give them growth, it's their choice. If they think open source can do it for them, it's great. What is even better is when they use opportunities involving both technologies. Let's be honest, there is nothing called 'free' in the world today. If users get something free and are stuck with it, and then have to pay somebody to help them use or maintain it, it is not 'free' ultimately. So at the end of the day, there is nothing that is totally free. Ultimately, it's about the customers and developers. And beyond all that, it is about innovation.

Q You just mentioned the interoperability factor. Windows 8 is being heavily criticised for not being friendly with open source because of the secure-boot feature. It is being said that users will not be able to boot Linux operating systems on Windows 8 PCs. How do you defend that?

Secure boot attempts to protect the PC against boot loader attacks, which can compromise a system before the OS even loads. Secure boot is actually a feature of Unified Extensible Firmware Interface (UEFI), a new type of boot environment that has gradually been replacing the standard BIOS process. Windows 8 taps into UEFI's secure boot to ensure that the pre-OS environment is safe and secure. The secure-boot feature is an innovation that has come through to ensure that there is security. I think, today, security is a major concern,